If Anything Is Wrong

1.
It was Wednesday when we spent the afternoon at the bus shelter across from the pharmacy.

Thursday.

2.
Yichen leaned her blue bicycle against the rail beside the shelter.

green

3.
We sat on the third bench from the road.

second

The vending machine was beside it.

4.
For a few minutes the rain stopped without the sky changing. The glass behind us remained gray, except for one rectangular patch that caught the pharmacy sign and held it there.

Across the road, a shop door opened and shut. Warm air reached the curb and nowhere else.

Yichen touched the toe of her shoe to an old bus ticket pressed flat against the pavement. She turned it over once and left it white side up.

I remember this because there was nothing else to look at.

receipt, not ticket

5.
I checked the time at 5:18 p.m.

shortly after five

6.
Yichen forgot her scarf on the bench.

left

7.

It was a thin scarf, light enough that one end lifted whenever a bus passed.

"You'll forget that," I said.

"Okay."

She did not pick it up.

A few minutes later I asked whether something had happened at school.

"No."

I waited.

Sometimes a second answer followed if I did not ask another question too quickly. I had learned this without deciding to learn it. If I filled the silence, she would let the first answer stand. If I left it alone, there was sometimes another sentence after ten seconds, or twenty, usually beginning with actually or it's just that.

I had become good at pretending not to count.

A bus arrived. Three people stood. The doors folded open and shut again.

I waited longer.

This time the second answer did not come.

She rubbed one thumb against the side of her index finger, the way she did when her hands were cold.

I looked at her face and thought she was angry.

tired

8.

The draft reads:

> "You'll forget that," I said.
> "Sure," she said.

"Okay."

9.

She looked tired.

Retain as written.

10.

We let the next bus go.

Then another.

After a while, waiting stopped feeling like an activity. The shelter filled and emptied around us. People arrived with umbrellas dripping onto their shoes, checked the route

map, complained into their phones, then disappeared through the folding doors. Every few minutes there was engine noise, wet tires, footsteps, and then the shelter belonged to whoever had not boarded yet.

Yichen read advertisements all the way to the bottom. Not the large words, which everyone read, but the numbers underneath: telephone lines, addresses, dates of promotions.

Once she pointed out that a tutoring center had printed two different closing dates on the same poster.

I asked why she had noticed.

"They're both there."

That was apparently sufficient reason.

A man came in, shook his umbrella outside the shelter, then stepped inside and asked whether the 19 stopped there.

Yichen pointed at the route map.

He looked at it for several seconds.

"Does it?"

She pointed again.

He thanked her and left before the next bus came.

For a while neither of us said anything.

There were things we could do together without making them interesting. Waiting was one of them.

Retain as written.

11.

By then the buses had started to blur together for me.

Six buses passed before the rain started again.

12.

We decided to wait for the next one.

We waited for the next one.

The remainder may stand.

13.

The pharmacy across the road closed at six.

six thirty

14.

I thought she wanted to go home.

Retain through:

I thought.

Delete the remainder.

15.

I did not ask what she meant.

No correction.

16.

When the rain came back, it came harder.

A child in a yellow coat stepped directly into the first deep patch of water outside the shelter. His mother pulled him back by the hood. He waited until she looked away and did it again with the other foot.

The receipt from earlier had softened in the rain. Water bent the paper against the pavement until the printed side could no longer be read.

Each time a bus approached, its headlights appeared first as two pale rectangles in the shelter glass. Then the rectangles widened, broke against the water, and became a bus.

Yichen moved her bag so the child could sit.

I had the book I meant to lend her in my backpack. She had the scarf beside her. The rain was loud enough that we did not have to account for every silence.

At some point she pulled her sleeves over her hands.

I remember thinking that we had become unusually good at doing nothing together.

A bus stopped. Nobody in the shelter moved.

The driver waited, looked at us through the windshield, and shut the doors.

For years I remembered the water running from the edge of the shelter roof in a straight line beside us. In my memory, the child put one shoe under it and watched the water strike the toe.

It is one of the clearest images I have from that afternoon.

Delete in full.

The receipt was under the bench.

17.

Restore the omitted passage concerning the vending machine.

The following Monday, the vending machine took my coin and gave me nothing.

“You pressed it wrong,” Yichen said.

“There is one button.”

“That doesn’t mean you pressed it right.”

I pressed it again.

Nothing happened.

She moved me aside and pressed the same button.

Nothing happened.

“Good,” I said.

“That proves nothing.”

“It proves there are two of us who can’t press one button.”

“That’s not what it proves.”

She hit the return lever. The coin did not come back.

Then, without either of us touching anything, the machine made a mechanical sound and dropped a can of coffee neither of us had selected.

Yichen picked it up.

“Pattern found.”

“What pattern?”

“It gives you the wrong thing if you wait long enough.”

“That’s not a pattern.”

She put the coffee on top of the machine and tried another coin.

The second coin came back immediately.

“See?”

“No.”

“You’re not very scientific.”

“You’ve had two trials.”

“Exactly.”

The next afternoon she told me she had solved the machine.

I asked how.

"I solved the coffee."

"That isn't an answer."

"It is if you know what happened."

I did know what had happened.

For years afterward, I could not pass that kind of vending machine without checking whether it had a return lever.

18.

A few weeks later, on the first Friday in November, the stationery shop near school was closed when we got there.

Yichen checked the sign.

"It says five."

I checked my phone.

"It's five twelve."

"Yes."

We stood outside for a while as if identifying the contradiction might cause the door to open.

It did not.

There was another stationery shop two streets away. She said it was worse.

I asked what could be worse about a stationery shop.

"The pens."

"What's wrong with the pens?"

"They're bad."

This seemed to be the entire classification system.

We went anyway.

She needed mechanical-pencil lead. I needed nothing and bought an eraser because I had walked there.

She held up two tubes of 0.5 mm lead.

"They changed the packaging."

"You say that like they changed the formula."

"They might have."

"It's graphite."

She looked at me.

I stopped contributing.

At the register she discovered she had brought enough money for either the lead or the notebook she had also picked up, but not both. I offered her two yuan.

“No.”

“You’re short two yuan.”

“I know.”

“That’s usually when two yuan helps.”

She put the notebook back.

Outside, she asked to borrow the eraser I had just bought.

“You had the option to buy an eraser.”

“I didn’t need one then.”

“You need one thirty seconds later.”

“Yes.”

I gave it to her.

She put it in her pocket and forgot to return it.

0.7 mm, not 0.5.

19.

There are parts of that autumn I may have arranged later.

I remember the wet cuffs of my trousers more clearly than most of what we said. I remember the pharmacy sign. I remember her scarf on the bench after she stood up.

The silences are harder.

Perhaps I supplied some of their shape later.

No correction.

20.

The last thing she said to me before I got on the bus was, “Your bus is here.”

I said, “Your bus is here.”

He got on the bus.

21.

The draft later reads:

My father might be going to Seoul.

I told Yichen after school several days before the afternoon at the shelter.

"When?"

"I don't know."

"For work?"

"I think so."

She nodded.

I said there was a chance I would go with him.

She looked at me.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"So?"

"So what?"

"You said you might go."

"Yeah."

She waited.

I kicked the side of the curb with my shoe.

"What would you think if I did?"

"About Seoul?"

"About me going."

"What am I supposed to think?"

"I don't know."

"Then why are you asking?"

"I'm just asking."

She looked down the road.

I said something about not knowing whether it would happen anyway.

A bus turned at the intersection and continued past us.

She answered before it disappeared.

Move this passage before the bus-shelter section.

22.

She said she would probably miss me.

Delete "probably."

23.

For several nights I tried to imagine Seoul.

Mostly I imagined practical things.

Whether my phone would still work.

Whether I would have to wake up earlier.

Whether my father would know the bus routes.

Whether the room would have a desk.

I searched photographs of neighborhoods I had never heard of and tried to decide whether they looked like places where I could live.

Sometimes I looked at the distance on a map.

Sometimes I checked how long the flight took.

I made a list of things I would pack and lost the list.

At school, I found myself looking at objects I would not normally have considered taking: a ruler, a broken pen, the keychain on my bag.

No correction.

24.

I brought a book to the shelter on Thursday because I had told Yichen I would lend it to her.

It stayed in the bottom of my bag.

At some point the corner of the cover pressed into my notebook hard enough to leave a triangular mark on several pages.

I noticed the mark when I got home.

I do not remember deciding not to give her the book.

I only remember that I did not.

front pocket, not the bottom of the bag

25.

By the time my bus came, I remember feeling that something had already been settled.

No correction.

26.

My father sent me a photograph from Seoul that Sunday. It showed a hotel window, half a curtain, and the corner of a television.

He had flown out on Saturday.

Friday.

The photograph was sent Sunday.

27.

I remember a song playing from the pharmacy that afternoon.

I have changed the title three times while writing this.

It was none of those songs.

28.

The draft says very little about what happened afterward.

On October 28, Yichen sent me a photograph of a building with narrow windows and an external staircase.

No message.

I replied:

ugly

She replied:

I like the stairs.

I asked:

where is that

She answered:

you always hate stairs

I wrote:

only bad stairs

She sent:

exactly

I never found out where the building was.

In November I sent her a song late at night.

The next morning she wrote:

the beginning is better

I asked:

than the rest?

No answer.

Four days later she sent me a different song.

I replied before I had finished it:

> this one is worse

She wrote:

> you haven't reached the good part
> how do you know
> you replied too fast

In December she sent a photograph of a dog sleeping under a table.

I asked whose dog it was.

> not important

I asked anyway.

She sent:

> my cousin's

I wrote:

> okay

That was the conversation.

At some point she asked whether I still had a photograph from a school trip.

I sent three.

> not those

I sent two more.

> no

Two days later I found another folder and sent one from the back of a classroom.

> yes

I asked what she needed it for.

She replied several hours later:

> something

That evening she asked why my hair looked like that in the photograph.

I said I was fourteen.

She wrote:

> so was everyone else

We talked until after midnight.

January contained long conversations about things I no longer understand from the messages alone.

One begins:

> he did it again

My answer is:

> there is no way

Then:

> I literally watched him

I do not know who he was.

Another conversation is mostly photographs of badly written homework questions.

On January 22 we exchanged forty-three messages.

On January 23, thirty-one.

On January 24, none.

On January 25, she asked whether I had eaten lunch.

In March there was one Saturday when we sent each other almost sixty messages, most of them about a teacher neither of us liked.

A week later there were three.

One was a photograph of a broken zipper.

One was:

> did you finish it

I no longer know what it referred to.

The third was my answer:

> almost

On April 7 she sent:

> are you awake

I was.

We talked for twenty minutes.

Nothing in the conversation explains why she asked.

The next afternoon I sent her a photograph of a worksheet.

She replied:

> page 2

I had sent page 2.

I sent it again.

She replied:

nvm

On May 14 she wrote:

I think I left my ruler with you.

I found a ruler in the front pocket of my backpack.

I wrote:

I can bring it tomorrow.

She replied:

I won't be home tomorrow.

I wrote:

Okay.

There is nothing else on that date.

On May 18 she sent me a photograph of a vending machine.

I wrote:

did you fix this one too

She replied:

no
different one

I asked what was wrong with it.

nothing

On May 19 we exchanged seventeen messages.

On May 23, one.

There were no messages on May 24.

There were nine on May 25.

July was busier.

On July 3 we talked for almost two hours.

On July 8 she sent me five photographs from the same street because, according to her, I had looked at the wrong thing in the first four.

On July 11 I asked whether she was going to the bookstore near school.

She wrote:

maybe

We both went.

Neither of us bought anything.

On July 17 she sent:

remind me tomorrow

I asked:

of what

There was no answer.

The next day she sent me a photograph of a notebook.

I did not ask whether that was what I was supposed to remember.

On July 22 I sent her something at 4:16 p.m.

There is no reply.

On July 26 she sent a link.

We exchanged twenty-six messages about it.

On July 29 I asked:

when are you leaving

She replied:

next week

I wrote:

oh

A minute later:

what day

She sent the date.

We talked about something else.

Yichen moved to another city the following week.

She sent me a photograph from the train.

I wrote:

your window is filthy

She replied:

it's raining

Later she sent another photograph, this one of the station platform.

I asked if she had arrived.

almost

That evening:

here

The next day I asked whether the room was okay.

> small
> bad small?
> just small

A week later she sent a photograph of a desk against a wall.

I wrote:

> yours?
> yes
> looks depressing
> I like it
> of course you do

She sent a photograph of the window beside it.

In the first two weeks after she moved, we spoke almost every day.

By September there are gaps.

Four days.

Then a conversation lasting an hour.

Seven days.

Then three photographs in one afternoon.

I sent a question on September 19.

She did not answer.

On September 27 she sent me a link with no reference to the question.

I replied to the link.

We argued about it until after midnight.

In October she called me once.

The call lasted seven minutes.

I do not remember what we discussed.

There is another message later that month:

> call me when you see this

I apparently did.

There is no record of that call either.

On November 6 I wrote:

> did you ever find it

She replied:

find what

I no longer know.

There are messages I remember that I cannot find.

There are messages I can find that I do not remember at all.

One ends:

tell me later

I do not know whether I did.

The draft originally ends this section with the sentence:

After she moved, our conversations became shorter.

The omission of what happened afterward need not be treated as an error.

The building was a library.

The photograph was sent October 28.

The ruler was mine.

29.

We began speaking less after you moved.

Before.

30.

The last message has a date.

I do not have a date for when it became clear there would not be another.

I have looked.

MESSAGE ATTACHED TO THE ORIGINAL DRAFT

I wrote something.

You don't have to reply.

If anything is wrong, just fix it.